

posting videos and truly enjoyed content creation. It became something I genuinely looked forward to, and I feel that shift changed everything for me," she says.

Kavya Mahajan, who splits his time between content creation and contributing to his family's real estate firm Property Station, recalls how he started posting aesthetic images and videos during college. "I like creative direction. There is always a storyline in my videos," he says. As his content began hitting over a million views organically, brand deals followed. But with success came challenges, including payment delays that stretched for months. He explains, "Now I ask for 50% advance and send a legal notice over delays."

For Priyam Yonzon, what began as instinctive posting became her chosen means of livelihood after a reality show appearance and an exclusive retail partnership. At 23, she earns purely through brand campaigns. "When I look at people who are around my age, they are still looking for jobs," she says. But she is quick to underline the discipline the profession demands, "If you want to sustain yourself, you cannot treat it simply like a side hustle. I shoot, edit, style and plan everything myself. I am a one-person army."

There are niches here. For instance, in gaming, earnings flow in via views, memberships for special content, affiliates and brand partnerships.

Plus, YouTube tools like Super Chat, Super Stickers, and Channel Memberships, are helping with earnings, with over 45,000 channels in India earning from these products in a single month.

Over 40% of eligible creators in India are enrolled in its shop-

THE BIG BUCKS



Creator-influenced spending in India projected to exceed \$1 trillion annually by 2030*



Annual Income Potential: Mega creators (1 Million+) can go well into double-digit crores; macro creators (500K-1 Million) ₹20 lakh to ₹1.5 crore



Income Potential Per Post: Mid-tier creators (100K-500K): ₹75,000 to ₹3 lakh; micro creators (10K-100K): ₹15,000 to ₹1 lakh; nano creators (1K-10K): ₹2,000 to ₹15,000

SOURCE INCOME ESTIMATES BY INDUSTRY EXPERTS; *2025 BCG REPORT - 'FROM CONTENT TO COMMERCE: MAPPING INDIA'S CREATOR ECONOMY'

ping affiliate programme, says Soni of YouTube. While YouTube Shorts can work best for reaching new audiences quickly, Gaurang believes long form is the real game. "With good engagement comes great earning opportunities that are generally much higher in long form," he adds.

THE MONETISATION GAME

As the creator economy matures, the search for the "right fit" has become critical for both brands and creators. Sitting between the two is a fast-growing layer of talent-management companies and social media managers.

Social media consultant Ma-yank Jha describes the evolution of content creation simply, "From hobby to business to professional ecosystem. That has been the journey of the last decade." There are clear distinctions between creators based on their following: Nano (1,000 to 10,000), micro (10,000-100,000), mid-tier (100,000-500,000), macro (500,000 to 1 million) and mega (over 1 million). Rate cards are now far more standardised. Fashion and beauty drive campaign volume, while technology and auto often command the biggest cheques, particularly in long-form video formats.

Being in the business of developing laptops and tools for gamers and content creators, Bruce Lin, NB Marketing Manager of South Asia at MSI, observes how "nowadays, creating quality content isn't the biggest challenge for young talents; it's about integrating their creativity effectively and standing out in a competitive landscape".

Aditi Shrivastava, Co-founder and CEO of digital media company Pocket Aces, says the pandemic accelerated the adoption of short-form and self-shot creator content. The company's talent